Flat

I loved driving on the backroads, through the fields of corn.

"Whoa. did you feel that?"

"What?"

"I feel like you better go check that out."

He pulled over to the edge of the road to get out and check on the tire. As he stepped down from the cab of the pick-up and glanced toward the ground,

"Shit, it's a flat."

I couldn't help but chuckle. I noticed sitting in the cupholder, his dab pen. I laughed harder.

“Get out and help me with the jack.”

Cracking up, I grabbed the door handle and stumbled out of the truck cabin to the pavement. I made my way to the rear of the bed and helped him to pull down the tailgate.

“What’s with all the trash?”

“It’s not trash, I pulled it out of the dumpster at work.”

“If you got it from the dumpster, I am pretty sure that makes it trash.”

“Just help me move it over.”

Together we pushed the garbage to the side and reached towards the back to grab the jack and the spare tire. I stood back and watched as he knelt down and began to unscrew the nuts.

“Wanna help out, or‘d you rather just stand there?”

“I'd rather just stand here.” I knelt down.

“You really have no idea what you are doing, do you?”

“We have triple A.”

“Just pump the jack for me.”

“Like this?”

It was now his turn to laugh. He took the handle from my hand and finished raising the jack. I started to roll the spare over.

“I think your spare might be flat.”

I fought back laughter.

“What do you mean?” He grabbed the tire, then threw it, then kicked it, then picked it up again and threw it into the corn. I lost it.

“It’s not funny.”

“I think it is.”

“Cause you can, it’s not your car.”

“You don’t have to be so serious about it.”

“I do, I can’t afford a new tire and another spare.”

“You’ll figure it out, things usually work out.”

“For you.”

“What is that supposed to mean?”

“I have to pay for this on my own. I have to deal with this on my own.”

“I am getting pretty tired of your, whole, woe is me, my life is so hard, I have to do everything mysel-”

“I do have to do everything myself, I don’t live in your golden ivory tower. I am out here working everyday just so I can afford gas.”

“I have a job, too. I-”

“Max, you don’t need that job. You just work for fun spending money.”

“I still have a job. Even if my parents help out with some things. I-”

“Your parents help with everything. Who bought you your car? Who pays for your gas? Who pa-”

“You know what, your parents would help you more too. I know your parents. If you called, your dad would help.”

“It’s not that simple. You know it's not.”

“I don't know that, it's just stup-”

“Shit.”

“Wh-”

“It’s the cops.”

I followed his gaze.

“It’s just a cart, they aren’t gonna care. They probably won’t even notice.”

“Maybe in the big city they have bigger problems, but out here, cops are assholes, especially Boob.”

The cop car dipped under the apex of the nearest hill.

“Should I try and grab it?”

“Forget it, that’d be more suspicious. Just keep him distracted.”

Just as the car rounded the hill, I saw him look down the road, stand up a little straighter, smile politely, and wave. The cop car flashed its lights and pulled over to the side of the road. I threw on my kindest smile and waved. Boob stepped out of his car.

“Havin’ a little trouble with your truck there, boys?”

“Yeah, my front left tire blew right up on that hill,”

Boob was making his way over to the front of the truck. He stuck his head up and was just about to take a look inside.

“You don’t happen to have a spare tire on you, do you, sir?” I took care to emphasize ‘sir’. He turned to look at me.

“‘Fraid not. Not for a vehicle of this size. But I can help get you boys a tow, if that’s what you need.” He resumed his walk towards the front and began to crane his neck for a sweep of the interior.

“No sir, that won’t be necessary. I think I got a buddy I can call who’s got a spare.”

Boob turned back again, he didn’t seem interested in the flat tire anymore.

“Yeah, we’ll take care of this. Thank you for your help, officer.”

He made his way back over to us, looking one last time at the driver window, but too far away now to make anything out. His attention had now turned to us.

“What were you two boys doin’ out here, anyhow?

“Just going for a driv-”

“We were on our way to my grandma's house, takin’ her some of this old stuff I got from my job at the middle school.”

Boob looked at me then to him, then back at me. Boob walked over to the trunk and looked in.

“This junk here in the trunk?” Boob leaned back, let out a laugh and clapped his belly. I realized that must’ve been a joke, we both smiled and faked a chuckle as best we could.

“‘You boys want me to wait with ya till your friend brings you the spare? Give one-a you a ride somewhere, maybe?”

“No, w-”

“I think we’re alright.”

“Well, you call if you need anything. I think you know the number.” Boob winked and began walking back toward his car.

“Ha. We’ll be sure to do that, thanks for stopping by, Boo-” Shit. “officer.”

He stopped mid-step, and began to turn, face puckered.

“What did you sa-”

"I'm sorry, sir, I didn't-"

"Why don't you open up that truck of yours and let me take a look inside."

Boob was standing over us now, his hot breath reeked.

"I don’t think you can do that. There’s probable cause, and-”

“Hey, it’s my truck. Yes, you’re welcome to look, take your time.”

He reached in his pocket, pulled out the key and handed it to Boob. Boob turned towards the car and pulled the handle.

“You won’t find anything,” I said.

Ryan kicked me just as Boob glowered back over his shoulder.

Boob first checked the door pocket, then under the seat, then, “What do we have he-”

Ryan moved first, I was quick to follow his lead. He pulled Boob back from the car and onto the ground. I grabbed his gun from the holster.

“Do it.”

Pop. Pop… Pop. Silence.

Blue turned purple. I dragged Boob into the corn. Ryan took one of the tires from Boob's car and I drove it into the corn.

“It’s only June.”

“Plenty of time.”

I laughed, he laughed and we drove away.